LEADER RESOURCE GUIDE

Fostering Mental Wellbeing Guide for Leaders

A practical, organisation-neutral guide to building psychological safety, compassionate leadership and healthy ways of working.

“The most meaningful way to succeed is to help others succeed.”

— Adam Grant, organisational psychologist

PURPOSE AND CONTENTS

Lead with mental wellbeing in mind

Leaders shape the everyday conditions in which people work. This guide helps leaders create a team culture that values mental wellbeing, psychological safety, connection and sustainable performance. It is not a clinical guide: leaders are not expected to diagnose, counsel or resolve a medical issue. Their role is to listen with care, respond appropriately and connect people with the right support.

> **Use this guide alongside your organisation's policies and support services.** Adapt the language, escalation routes, privacy requirements and wellbeing resources to your local context before using it with a team.

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Ground your leadership and connect to yourself

How you care for yourself, make space for connection and support people in one-to-ones has a meaningful effect on your team. Begin by connecting with yourself as a person and as a leader. This helps you lead with purpose, steadiness and openness.

> *"Connection is the energy that is created between people when they feel seen, heard, and valued."*
>
> — Brené Brown

Ground your own practice

- Reflect on your progress, what you have learned and what you value.
- Do a regular energy check: what helps you feel healthy, well and able to lead?
- Ask for help when you need it — from a manager, peer, coach or an appropriate wellbeing service.
- Use coaching, peer learning or practical tools to strengthen your own leadership capacity.

Model healthy norms

- Take real time away from work to rest and recharge; encourage others to plan time off too.
- Be visible about sustainable boundaries, breaks and switching off.
- Celebrate healthy choices and make space for social connection.
- Review workload and priorities rather than treating overload as a personal resilience issue.

Leader reflection

Before your next team meeting or one-to-one, ask: *What energy am I bringing? What might my team need from me today? What one action would make it safer or easier for someone to ask for support?*

Lead authentically and with care

Appropriate vulnerability can help normalise conversations about wellbeing. It does not mean sharing everything. The aim is to show that challenges are human, support is available and healthy ways of working are valued.

What authentic leadership can look like

- Share, at an appropriate level, how you are looking after your own wellbeing.
- Be honest that work and life can be challenging without making team members responsible for your feelings.
- Commit to healthy working practices and follow through.
- Acknowledge that remote, hybrid and onsite work can affect people differently.
- Communicate that adjusting to change can take time and that support is available.

Keep appropriate boundaries

- Consider the relationship and power dynamic before sharing something personal.
- Do not overshare in a way that makes an employee uncomfortable or places emotional responsibility on them.
- Do not assume that colleagues want to disclose personal information.
- Focus on what support, flexibility or resource could help — rather than seeking details.

Team norm to try

Open a team meeting with a short check-in, then make the norm explicit: “You do not need to share anything personal. This is simply space to recognise how we are arriving, what is important this week and what support could help us work well together.”

Prepare to talk openly about mental wellbeing

Open, respectful conversations can reduce stigma and lower barriers to seeking support. A leader does not need the perfect words; they need care, curiosity, patience and a clear understanding of the support route.

1. **Listen actively**
   Ask an open question such as “How are you, really?” then allow space. Listen to understand rather than moving quickly to a solution.

2. **Use respectful language**
   Avoid language that dismisses experience or implies that mental health challenges result from weakness or lack of willpower.

3. **Signal that wellbeing matters**
   Use team meetings and one-to-ones to remind people that wellbeing is important and that support services can be used preventively, not only in a crisis.

4. **Leave judgement behind**
   Be open-minded. Different cultures, identities and life experiences can affect how people describe stress, symptoms and help-seeking.

5. **Lead by example**
   Encourage practical self-care, healthy boundaries and sustainable work patterns — and demonstrate them yourself.

Helpful language

- “I have noticed things may feel difficult. How are you doing?”
- “What support would be useful right now?”
- “You do not have to share details. I want you to know that support is available.”
- “Would it help if I sent you our wellbeing and employee-support information?”

Language to avoid

- “You should not feel depressed.”
- “You have no reason to be anxious.”
- “Just try to be positive.”
- “Everyone is under pressure — you need to cope.”

Recognise and offer help when someone is struggling

Managers are not counsellors or therapists. Their responsibility is to notice meaningful changes, approach the person with care, manage work appropriately and connect them with relevant support. Do not try to diagnose a condition or investigate private medical information.

Changes worth noticing

One sign alone does not tell you what is happening. Look for sustained or significant changes such as:

- Repeated impatience, irritability or anger
- Withdrawal, isolation or increased conflict
- Unusual sensitivity or a notable shift in behaviour
- Reduced concentration, attendance or ability to manage normal work
- Signs that alcohol, drugs or another coping behaviour may be affecting work or safety

What a leader can do

- Choose a private, appropriate time and ask an open question with genuine interest.
- Listen more than you talk; do not pressure someone to explain.
- Ask what workplace support could help: priorities, workload, flexibility, time, connection or information.
- Share the relevant employee-support, HR, occupational health or leave information.
- Follow your organisation's safeguarding and escalation procedures if there is immediate safety concern.

Privacy matters. Do not request a diagnosis or try to uncover a medical or mental-health condition. Keep information shared with you confidential within the limits of your role and policy, and only involve others when necessary, authorised or required for safety.

Use a broader question

Instead of only asking "How are you?", try: "How has the transition been for you?" • "What is feeling most difficult at the moment?" • "What would make work more manageable this week?"

Use a team working-preferences exercise

There is no single way to recognise when someone is under pressure. A voluntary team working-preferences exercise can help people explain what helps them work well, how they prefer to receive feedback and what support may be useful when they feel stressed.

Questions to include

- What helps you do your best work?
- What can be a sign that you are under pressure?
- What support from a manager or colleague is useful when you are stressed?
- How do you prefer to receive feedback?
- What builds trust with you — and what can damage it?
- When do you tend to have the most energy for focused work?
- What boundaries help you maintain wellbeing?

Make it psychologically safe

- Keep participation voluntary; do not require personal disclosure.
- Let people decide what they share and with whom.
- Agree how the information will be stored, used and updated.
- Use insights to improve collaboration, not to label people or manage performance.
- Invite new team members to complete the exercise if they choose.

Four simple steps

1. **Give people thinking time**
   Share the questions and allow 20–30 minutes for individuals to reflect and write their own responses.

2. **Choose a sharing approach**
   People may share straight away or complete their reflections first, then discuss two or three points together in a dedicated session.

3. **Store with care**
   Keep voluntary profiles in an agreed team space with clear access and privacy expectations.

4. **Extend thoughtfully**
   Invite peers and managers to participate if useful. Revisit the exercise as relationships, roles and working needs change.

Respond with care and accountability

A supportive conversation can acknowledge the impact of behaviour while staying curious about what the person may need. The goal is not to excuse harmful behaviour; it is to address it constructively while offering appropriate support.

Situation: A manager has received feedback that a team member, Alex, became blaming and abrupt after a client call.

Manager: “Alex, I have heard that after the client call your feedback to the team felt blaming rather than constructive. I would like to understand what was happening for you.”

Alex: “I am sorry. I am exhausted and things at home have been stressful. I snapped.”

Avoid a purely corrective response

“You should contact the employee assistance programme, but I do not want to hear about this happening again. Please apologise. I expect better.”

Lead with care and clarity

“Thank you for being honest. The impact on the team still needs to be addressed, and an apology would be important. I also want to understand how you are managing. What support would make things more manageable?”

Manager: “This does not have to be about solving everything now. We could look at priorities, take our next one-to-one as a walking meeting, and I can send the employee-support information if you would find that useful.”

Manager: “Let us check in regularly about workload and how things are going. We can expect respectful behaviour from each other and also actively support each other through a difficult time.”

Remember

Do not make promises you cannot keep, diagnose the person or pressure them to disclose. If someone indicates they may be at immediate risk of harm, follow the organisation’s emergency or safeguarding process immediately.

Challenge assumptions about how work gets done

Wellbeing is not only an individual matter. Leaders can reduce avoidable stress by making work more realistic, flexible and sustainable while maintaining clarity about outcomes and performance.

1. **Offer practical flexibility**
   Where the role and business context allow, provide options such as flexible hours, adjusted schedules, focus time or meeting-light periods.

2. **Create boundaries**
   Help people protect conscious downtime. Review meeting habits, response expectations and work that regularly spills into personal time.

3. **Prioritise visibly**
   Clarify what is mission-critical, what can wait and what can stop. Reducing low-value work can be more helpful than asking people to be more resilient.

4. **Normalise different ways of working**
   Demonstrate genuine support for agreed flexibility. Make it clear that personal responsibilities and interruptions can be managed with trust and communication.

5. **Give adjustment time**
   Recognise that people may adapt differently to change, remote/hybrid arrangements or difficult circumstances. Check assumptions and stay patient.

> **Team question to use:** “What is making it unnecessarily hard to do good work at the moment — and what is one change within our control that would help?”

Resources, support and local adaptation

Before sharing this guide, tailor this page so employees and leaders know where to go for support. Keep the directory current, accessible and appropriate for each country or location.

Adapt this section for your organisation

- **Employee Assistance Programme (EAP):** [insert confidential support contact and access route]
- **HR / People Team:** [insert contact route for workplace support, policies and leave options]
- **Occupational Health:** [insert referral or advice route, where available]
- **Wellbeing benefits:** [insert counselling, coaching, health-plan or wellbeing resources]
- **Emergency / safeguarding route:** [insert local procedure and emergency contacts]
- **Manager support:** [insert manager peer network, coaching or leader community]

Before you use this guide

- Confirm local privacy, employment-law, data-protection and safeguarding requirements.
- Brief leaders on confidentiality and escalation expectations.
- Ensure support resources are genuine, current and accessible.
- Agree ownership, review cycle and a feedback route.

Important reminder

This guide supports compassionate leadership; it is not medical, legal or clinical advice. In an emergency or where someone may be at immediate risk, use local emergency and safeguarding procedures.

“Anything that is human is mentionable, and anything that is mentionable can be more manageable.”

— Fred Rogers

Lead in ways that help people feel seen, heard and supported.

Small, intentional choices — listening fully, creating clarity, respecting boundaries, checking workload and connecting people with support — can make a meaningful difference to wellbeing and sustainable performance.

Next step: Choose one practice from this guide to introduce this week, and one system or team norm that may need to change to make healthy work easier.